

Are AI voice synthesis/text to speech programs bad for environment?

Posted by u/bicyclefortwo • 0 points • 8 comments

I know ChatGpt will consume a fuckload of energy and water, something like 1-3 bottles per hundred words. So I don't use it, as well as the fact that there's nothing it can do that I can't just Google anyway. AI images are also totally useless and creepy to me. The only current AI trend I've seen any use in is how good it's made text to speech products. I've got ADHD and always found text to speech too unnatural to concentrate on, but it's really getting there in sounding expressive now.

I've been using Readly Reader recently and it's a option there. I could live without it obviously but I wanted to ask if anyone knows how much energy it uses. I ask because I'm not sure it counts as Generative, as it's mainly reading out pre-existing content and Alexa has been around for a long time without causing concern aside from privacy issues. Readly uses Unreal Speech, which I can't find anything about. Obviously ones trained on voices without permission are evil in their own way, but these specific ones seem created with the intention of text to speech.

Also don't evangelise to me about why I shouldn't care. I've made my decisions based on my own values and want to be informed so I can act on what I believe in. You won't change my opinion and you can't make me stop caring. Thx

Comments

u/mulch_v_bark • 1 points • 2025-03-30 16:11 UTC

An important bit of context that gets lost in a lot of these conversations about how much energy and water various tools use is the comparison. For example, if you eat a diet with a lot of meat and dairy, you're probably using more water than you'd think just by sitting quietly in a chair with your metabolism running. This is not me telling you your values are wrong – I'm saying your facts may be out of context.

Personally I think the ethical case against "big AI" is much stronger on artistic theft and cultural pollution grounds than on resource use grounds, and I avoid it. So I'm not an AI evangelist here. I'm sincerely saying you might want to look at this from different angles.

Anyother key issue here, a topic that's been deliberately muddled by big AI PR I think, is that there is no sharp line between "generative" and "regular" AI – I know even trusted commentators make this

distinction like it reflects some underlying structural truth, but it doesn't. It's like debating the environmental impacts of cars and thinking that green cars, like literally cars painted green, are more environmentally friendly. That's a purely surface-level feature of no practical importance.

A model of `_n_` parameters is basically using as much energy per use as any other model of `_n_` parameters (within certain reasonable assumptions) whether it's generating text, voice, smells, facial recognitions, or star ratings. Sepcifically, there's no categorical difference between Alexa and, say, ChatGPT – people get mad at them for different reasons but they shouldn't; pretty much any criticism of one will at least mostly apply to the other.

From 30 seconds of research it looks like Readly Reader runs on your device (i.e., offline). You can therefore tell how much energy it uses by the very simple metric of how hot your device gets while running it. You can compare this to the power used by watching a movie, playing a game, etc. Whatever gets hotter uses more electricity per second (or hour, or whatever) of your use. They also used power to train it, and you're sending at least a small price signal that makes retraining more likely, but data centers are a lot more efficient than edge devices.

I would really focus on the ethics of what this is doing to voice actors, say, rather than what it's doing to your carbon and water footprint. Yes, that matters, but it's likely in the range of, like, 10 minutes of extra driving per year; if you want to change your behaviors then as a person in the developed world that's going to be about diet, transportation, voting, etc. much more than about app choice.

u/bicyclefortwo • 1 points • 2025-03-30 16:27 UTC

I did give up meat years ago because of the environmental costs, and I don't eat a whole lot of dairy anyway. I hate AI on artistic theft grounds as well, which is why I was wondering about this one because it seems to only have a handful of pre-trained voices that I assume (?) would have been done with consent. That other one that boasted voices like Snoop Dogg and 'anyone you want' horrified me, but this one seems like a standard text to speech software, at least within it's Readly implementation.

That's super interesting about how murky it is, I think I just care about the cost/benefit of it all. I didn't like meat much anyway so it wasn't worth the cost, and Id hate to think my desire for convenience is burning up energy in a data centre somewhere.

u/mulch_v_bark • 2 points • 2025-03-30 16:37 UTC

Yeah, I mean, it seems like you're looking at a tool that at least mostly fits your ethics, or at least has costs that are reasonable in your framework? It has still used power in the past, it uses power when you run it, and it is probably interfering with demand for real voice actors, although not in your particular case. But at some horizon I guess we have to accept that the small harms are part of the background of living in an imperfect world. If I go for a walk I'm releasing microplastics from my shoe soles, but I'm not going to worry about that because it's not where I can do much good. We have a responsibility to improve what we can but also a right to live in the world we're in.

u/IfYouSeekAyReddit • 1 points • 2025-03-30 15:59 UTC

>there's nothing it can do that I can't just Google anyway

sorry to ignore your question but this part is just wrong

u/bicyclefortwo • 1 points • 2025-03-30 16:01 UTC

I'll elaborate: nothing I would personally need it to do that I can't Google. I like writing so I don't want it to write things for me. I've heard it's useful for coding grunt work but I don't code. Any questions I'd have I can just search online.

u/IfYouSeekAyReddit • 2 points • 2025-03-30 16:04 UTC

I mean yeah if you're asking simple questions you can use google but it's good for questions that require a lot of work and digging to get the answer to. For example "what's the average price per hour for a plumber with 3-5 experience in the Denver area who provides additional services like electrical and landscaping maintenance?" like yeah you can create a spreadsheet and do the math or you can have the answer in 20 seconds

u/bicyclefortwo • 2 points • 2025-03-30 16:12 UTC

I guess my issue with very specific questions like that is that I don't trust it not to get confused and give me the wrong answers. Google's AI has done that to me loads

u/IfYouSeekAyReddit • 2 points • 2025-03-30 16:45 UTC

I get that. I always ask for the source as well. Never a good idea to blindly trust AI